DAAT TEVUNOT: THE RAMHAL ON CREATION, GOOD AND EVIL, AND THE SOUL

Why Must Everything Physical Come to an End?

Daat Tevunot §126-128

Sefer: Daat Tevunot by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Sections:** §126-128
Shiur: Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's series on Daat Tevunot, Monday 29 May 2023

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Where we are in the book

After the Shavuot break the Rabbi placed the class within the structure of the book. Section 1 was the introduction, Section 2 dealt with the Yihud of Hashem, Section 3 with the hester, the concealment of that Yihud, Section 4 with the relationship of body and soul, and Section 5 with the nature of evil, its effect on humanity and the 6,000 years. Section 6, which we are in now, looks more closely at evil and at man's relationship with it.

At the start of the section (§126) the Ramhal said there are two kinds of "bad". The Rabbi said he prefers the word "bad" to "evil" here. The first kind is our lowliness, which was covered before Shavuot. The second kind, which begins in this class, is that in this physical world everything comes to an end.

A reminder: the three levels

The Rabbi reviewed the three levels from the previous classes, with level 1 as the highest and level 3 as the lowest:

- Adam was created on level 2. Had he chosen correctly he would have risen to level 1.
- He sinned and fell to level 3, which is where we are now.
- Our task is to climb from 3 to 2 and from 2 to 1. At the end of days we will go from 3 to 1, but as a process over time and not in an instant.

In this world a person always stays on level 3. Someone as great as Eliyahu HaNavi reaches the very top of level 3, which is basically the bottom of level 2. That is why Eliyahu did not die and was not buried. Adam on level 2 was not meant to die either.

Destruction belongs only to the lowest level

The Ramhal says that decay and destruction belong only to this physical world. Anything higher does not come to an end. The Rabbi gave angels as an example. An angel is not a winged creature. As Derech Hashem explains, it is the "filter" through which things are brought down level by level. An angel lasts as long as it has a role, and when its purpose is complete it is finished. But it does not decay the way physical things do.

Even on level 2, Adam and the whole of Gan Eden would not have been subject to destruction, although the possibility of destruction was already there in potential. Had Adam been rectified, Gan Eden itself would have become Olam Haba. There would have been "no two worlds". This world, perfected, would have been the world. The term "Gan Eden" for where souls go after death was borrowed later.

The Rabbi stressed that this is not a metaphor. "Adam was a real person." There was a real garden, real trees and real fruit, but they were physical on a level we cannot picture, like the level of Eliyahu.

Why Hashem created Adam on level 2

Why not create man on level 1 at once? Because Hashem gave him the potential to perfect himself and rise from level 2 to level 1 by his own effort. The Rabbi recalled from Section 5 how evil came about. The hashpaah, the divine flow, was dimmed. It was not switched off, because then nothing would exist. It was dimmed, and the more it is dimmed the lower the level. After the sin it was dimmed further, and that is how we reached level 3.

He brought the Hakhamim's comment on the spies. When Moshe speaks of Hashem's power after the sin of the spies, the word appears in a feminine form, and they explain that the divine energy was, as it were, weakened.

The section continues (§126): destruction applies only to imperfect creatures. That is why, once we are perfected after the 6,000 years, there will be no more destruction. The Rabbi explained that the process begins at 6,000 and continues to 10,000 and beyond, but "if you're around at 6, you're around for good".

The Neshamah's question and the hidden order of the world

In §127 the Neshamah asks: why does imperfection lead to destruction? What is the link?

In §128 the Sekhel begins to answer. On the surface the world looks scattered: different countries, species, plants and stars, each going its own way with no shared purpose. But anyone who studies the world carefully finds that everything is in order, from the top down. The Rabbi compared this to the Rambam's teaching that knowing God includes knowing the world. "If you want to understand an author, you read his books." The only "book" of God's we can read is the world around us.

The participants noted that modern ecology says something similar: everything is linked, and polluting a river affects the whole chain of life. The Rabbi agreed that this is true on the physical level. In Section 5 we saw the interlinked system on the spiritual level, and here the Ramhal applies it to the physical level too. He added that the Ramhal does not go into the details, "because I have no idea", but what matters is the principle. Everything is connected and serves one purpose.

Created for His kavod

That purpose, says the Ramhal, is Hashem's glory. Hazal say that everything God created, He created only for His kavod, and the verse in Yeshayahu says "everyone called by My name, I created for My glory".

The Rabbi warned against misreading this. Hashem does not need honour. Kavod is something Hashem created, like any of the other attributes. He created the ability for us to honour Him, to be in awe of Him and to say "wow, look at God". It is like the korbanot. The Torah calls them a "pleasing aroma", but Hashem does not need sacrifices. He made a system through which we can, as it were, please Him. In the same way He gave us the ability to call Him kind.

The class ended here, and the link between kavod and the physical world is left for Thursday.

Summary

- The second kind of "bad" is that everything physical comes to an end. This applies only to the post-sin, level 3 world, and not to angels or to Adam's level 2 existence.
- Gan Eden was real and physical, but on a refined level. Had Adam not sinned, it would itself have become Olam Haba.
- Hashem created Adam on level 2 so that man could raise himself to level 1. The fall came from the divine flow being dimmed further.
- Although the world looks scattered, it is one ordered system with one purpose, and understanding the world is part of understanding its Author.
- "Created for His kavod" means Hashem created the very possibility of being honoured. He does not need the honour.

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